

A NOVEL INSPIRED BY A TRUE STORY

AFTER THE THUNDER

The story of a boy who learned to fight —
and to let go

BY - KEYRONG P

Chapter 1 – The Boy Who Trembled Before the Storm

Long before he could read a single letter, Mateo already knew how to read danger.

One flash of lightning splitting the sky was enough to make something inside me — because let me tell it as if I were still him, as if I were still that boy — shrink until it was almost nothing. It wasn't the lightning. It was what came after. The thunder. That dry, heavy blow that rattled the windows, and that my body, without anyone ever teaching it, had learned to confuse with other things: doors slamming, voices climbing higher and higher, the exact sound of a house breaking apart from the inside.

I trembled every single day. Over anything. A plate hitting the floor, a chair dragged across the room, footsteps that fell a little too hard in the hallway. My whole childhood was one long flinch — a small body always ready to run, never knowing where.

And there's something I could barely admit even to myself: I came to fear my own mother. Not because she was the danger — she was, in fact, the very thing I was trying to protect — but because when she raised her voice to scold me, my body couldn't tell the difference. A reproach and a threat sounded the same inside my chest. I would freeze, not understanding why my heart slammed against my ribs, why my hands went damp, why the air suddenly wasn't enough. I was far too young to name what I now know was a fear I had been taught.

Because I grew up beneath a violent man.

I saw things no child should ever see. I saw that man hurt my mother. I saw my brother take what he did not deserve. And I saw myself, so small I barely reached his waist, screaming behind him with every ounce of strength my body could hold: “Leave her alone! Don't hurt her anymore!” A tiny voice trying to stop something enormous. A child doing a man's job, because there was no man willing to do it right.

The man who gave me his blood never knew how to show love. He only knew how to attack. With the years I would come to understand that his single act of constancy was inventing new ways to wound my mother — to keep the lie alive, to turn what should have been a shelter into a minefield where every step could go off.

Something broke in me, it's true. But something also woke up.

Because while other children played without ever looking over their shoulders, I already understood things meant for grown-ups. I read silences. I could smell a storm before it formed. I learned to study people the way you study the sky, searching for the sign before the strike. I won't dress it up: it hurt. But there, inside that wound, something different was born. My own way of seeing the world. My own ways of surviving.

In time, my mother would meet another man. At first I feared him, the way I feared everything. His temper, his punishments, his scolding all struck me as one more threat, and my child's mind filed him away at once under danger.

How wrong I was. But that story isn't ready to be told yet.

I learned to fear the one who would end up saving me, and to call “father” the one who only knew how to destroy. It would take me years to understand that fear, sometimes, disguises itself as love... and that love, other times, arrives dressed as the very thing we fear most. Mateo still didn't know which of those two men would teach him to become who he is today.

(Continued in the next chapter...)

Chapter 2 — The Stranger Who Arrived Dressed as Fear

I never imagined a person could have another father.

To a child, the world is a house with fixed walls, and even if those walls were cracked, they were mine. That's why, when everything began to move, I felt the ground open beneath my feet.

First came the separation. That word grown-ups say softly, as if whispering it might make it hurt less — but a child hears it at full volume. My parents separated, and with them went the only version of the world I had ever known. Then came something my young mind couldn't process: my mother began to see someone else.

I saw things I shouldn't have seen. I won't spell them out, because there are images a person keeps not to remember them, but to learn to carry them in silence. Yet they lodged inside me, and I honestly believe that's where a wound formed that would take me years to even name.

And then he appeared. The stranger.

A new man at the door, with a voice I didn't recognize, filling spaces that weren't his to fill — or so I believed back then. My mind, that mind already trained to read danger before it could read words, did the only thing it knew how to do: it filed him away instantly under threats. Another man. Another risk. Another reason to stay on guard.

I didn't understand — how could I, at that age? — that my mother wasn't looking for a replacement or a fling. She was looking, with her nails and her whole heart, for what was best for my brother and me. She was trying to build us a roof that wouldn't crack. But the boy I was couldn't see that yet. The boy only felt fear. And fear, when it's the only thing you've ever known, disguises itself as certainty.

So I watched him arrive, convinced he was bringing a storm.

I didn't know he was bringing, for the very first time, calm.

It took me years to realize something that shakes me to this day: the man I welcomed with fear was the first who never gave me a reason for it. And while I kept watch over him, waiting for a blow that never came, I couldn't see who was truly failing me... from a distance, with promises he never meant to keep.

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Chapter 3 — The Father Who Promised Nothing (and Was Always There)

I was eight years old when I began to understand.

There was no exact moment, no lightning bolt of revelation. It was something slower, quieter: the steady piling-up of small gestures that, added together, ended up shouting a truth I didn't want to accept.

My biological father lived on promises. I'll come this weekend. I'll bring your school supplies. We'll take a trip. I'll buy you clothes. Big, shining words, thrown out over the phone or in passing, the kind that light up a child's chest with hope. And I waited. I would sit and wait for the weekend that never came, for the supplies that never appeared, for the trip that existed only in his mouth. Every broken promise was one more small crack, until I understood something brutal for a child to learn: we didn't matter to him. In time I realized it wasn't even about us. We were merely the instrument. The only thing he truly wanted was to hurt my mother, to wound her through our hope.

He never managed it. She was stronger than all his lies combined. And while that man spent his energy building disappointments, there was another who did the exact opposite — without announcing it, without an audience, without applause.

My stepfather never promised me anything. He was simply there. He was there when school supplies had to be bought, and he bought them. He was there when we needed clothes, and there they were. He was there when I got sick in the middle of the night — those nights when a child measures love by who stays awake beside him. He was there in the big things and the invisible ones, in the kind of things you don't brag about because you simply do them. And without giving me a single speech, he taught me what it meant to be a man: values, responsibility, the idea that family isn't the blood you carry, but the people who choose to stay.

One day I looked at him — truly looked at him — and realized that man had been my father for years. Not because of a document, or a last name. Because of presence. Because of choice. Because of love. How unfair I had been to him in my frightened child's mind. And how grateful I would be, for the rest of my life, that I had been wrong.

I learned that a father isn't the one who gives you life, but the one who chooses to be in it. Yet just when I finally felt I had found solid ground — that I finally had a real family — came the news that would move everything beneath my feet again. We were going to move. And with that move, without my knowing it, a whole new chapter of my story would begin.

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Chapter 4 — Starting Over (Again)

There's a quiet cruelty in having to leave behind what you finally felt was yours.

For several years, that first place had been my whole world. There I had made friends — the kind you make without effort as a child, running down the same streets, sharing the same afternoons. I met people who stayed etched in me, learned the corners, the shortcuts, the sounds of that neighborhood that no longer frightened me. For the first time, a place didn't put me on alert. It gave me a sense of belonging.

And then came the move.

The ground shifting again. Boxes again, the mess, that smell of an empty house that announces nothing will ever be the same. We were going to another area. A new school. New faces. A completely blank map I would have to learn to walk alone.

I won't lie: it was hard. Brutally hard. The hardest part wasn't the place itself, but the uncertainty. Not knowing what would come. Walking into a classroom full of personalities who already knew one another, where I was the stranger — ironic, after having feared strangers so much. And there was something else that made me feel small: many of those people came from fairly well-off families. Worlds different from mine. For a moment I felt I didn't fit, that I carried a story too heavy for a place where everyone seemed to have it so easy.

But something had changed in me without my noticing. That boy who trembled at every sound had learned, through sheer survival, to observe before he feared. And this time, for the first time, the observing found no danger. It found opportunity.

Little by little, I began to build bridges. One friend, then another. New goals. Purposes I wouldn't have dared to dream of before. And in time we understood something that gave meaning to all the uprooting: moving there was going to make our lives better.

And it did. Not like one of those empty promises I already knew so well. For real.

I discovered that starting over isn't always a punishment; sometimes it's life handing you a clean canvas after so many crooked strokes. What I still couldn't imagine was that the best chapter of my childhood was about to begin — among desks, uniforms, and one word that would change everything: school.

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Chapter 5 — The Best Years, Among Desks and Challenges

If I had to choose the greatest, brightest stage of my life, I wouldn't hesitate for a second: school.

It was five years. And I dare say, without exaggerating, they were the best years in the world.

It's a strange thing. The same boy who had grown up measuring danger, bracing for shouts, carrying wounds too heavy for his age, found in those classrooms something he'd never had in such abundance: people. Real friends. People who crossed my path to teach me, each in their own way, something I needed to learn.

Every day was a challenge. Not the challenges of fear, but the other kind — the good ones: learning something new, pushing myself, daring. I went on trips, on tours, everywhere a student's life took me. And in each of those places I left behind a piece of that frightened boy and picked up, in exchange, a piece of the man I was beginning to be.

I learned so much. And I don't mean only subjects, exams, or grades. I learned to laugh out loud, without glancing over my shoulder waiting for the storm. I learned to trust people. I learned that I, too, could have dreams, goals, a future not defined by what had happened to me, but by what I chose to do with it.

That boy who trembled at lightning was now running toward life with open arms. And though the scars were still there — they always are — they no longer gave the orders. Now they were just the map of where I came from, not the destination I was headed toward.

Five years that passed the way good things pass: far too quickly. And suddenly, almost without noticing, I was standing before a new door. Bigger. More serious. More grown-up.

University was waiting for me.

School gave me back something fear had stolen from me as a boy: the will to live. But life, which never stops setting tests, had a different stage in store — one where no one would treat me like a child anymore, and where I'd have to discover, once and for all, what kind of man I had become. University wasn't just a new school. It was the true beginning of my story as an adult.

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Chapter 6 — I

Learned to Fight, and

I Learned to Let Go

I'm going to confess something that still makes me laugh.

The day I started university, I walked in tricked. Literally. My parents took me there on some excuse, and by the time I realized it, I was already enrolled in a course. Me — not looking my best at all, carrying some random bag, wearing a red shirt I used as pajamas and a pair of flip-flops on my feet. God. The worst possible way to begin university life. And as if the universe wanted to finish me off, guess what the first class was? Calculus.

There I was: in pajamas, in flip-flops, facing the hardest numbers in the world, not quite understanding how I'd ended up in that room. And no, it didn't go well. Not at first. The term ended and I had failed three of my four subjects. Three out of four. I remember the exact feeling: the tears, the disappointment in myself, that weight in my chest so familiar, so much like the fear of childhood but with a new name: failure.

There was nothing left to do but what I always ended up doing in the moments that mattered: talk to my father. The one who truly was. And he — who could have scolded me, who could have laid down the law — did something I will never forget.

He let me choose.

He put the decision in my hands. He treated me, at last, like the man I was trying to be. And I chose. I chose to study. I chose it for real.

The courses that followed, I passed with good grades — not because I'd suddenly turned brilliant, but because for the first time I took it seriously, with the full weight of a decision that had been mine and no one else's. It was intense. I won't soften it. That whole process demanded every last gram of strength I had been gathering since I was a child.

And maybe that's exactly why I made it. Because I already knew about surviving. I already knew about getting back up. I'd been doing it my whole life.

When I look back, I see the boy who trembled at lightning. The one who screamed behind a violent man to protect his mother. The one who feared the stranger who turned out to be his real father. The one who had to start over, again and again. And I see that young man in pajamas and flip-flops, crying over three failed subjects.

They are all me. Not one of them is expendable. Each one carried me here.

Because a young man who lived his life through so much change learned, almost without meaning to, the two most important lessons there are: I learned to fight, and I learned to let go. To fight for what's worth it, and to release what only weighed me down. To honor the blood that chooses to stay, and to let go of the blood that only knew how to wound.

I haven't arrived. Let that be clear. I am not a finished story.

But I get better every day. And for the boy I once was — the one who trembled with fear every single day of his life — becoming a man who gets better every day is, quite simply, the happy ending I never believed I deserved.

If there's one thing I learned along this whole road, it's this: we are not what happened to us. We are what we decide to do with it. The boy who trembled became a man who chooses. And if my story reached your hands, maybe it's because you, too, have a thunder to outrun and a person to become. Don't be afraid. I didn't know I could either. And here I am.

The End.

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